

Netherlands Itinerary

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Amsterdam: Canal Light, Bicycle Bells & the Quiet Genius of the Dutch Golden Age

Amsterdam, before you arrive, exists mostly as a collage of associations. Canals. Bicycles. Tulips you won't see if you go in October. Some combination of art-history-postcards and the city's tolerant, slightly raffish reputation. What is startling is how completely the actual place absorbs and quietly outshines all of that. Within an hour of dropping our bags, we were walking along the **Prinsengracht** at dusk, watching the gabled houses double themselves in the water, and realising the city was going to be far more handsome and far less obvious than we had let ourselves expect.

We had four full days here. It felt like the right amount of time to walk slowly, eat well, get usefully lost in three or four neighbourhoods, and not feel as if we were ticking boxes. Amsterdam rewards a lower gear. It does not reward a list.

Day 1

The Canal Ring: A City Designed in Water

The **Grachtengordel**—the Canal Ring—is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and the spine around which the rest of the city hangs. Three semicircular canals (the **Herengracht**, **Keizersgracht** and **Prinsengracht**) ring the medieval core in a 17th-century feat of urban planning that still, four centuries later, looks like the work of people who knew exactly what they were doing. Walking these canals at any hour is essentially the city's main attraction, and you get it for free.

We did a small evening canal cruise on our second night, which we'd resisted on principle and then loved without reservation. Seeing the houses from the water—the leaning facades, the hooks at the top of every gable for hauling furniture up the outside, the bridges stacked one inside the next—reframes the whole city. Do it. It's the least cool, most worthwhile hour you'll spend.

Amsterdam at dusk along the Prinsengracht: bicycle bells, the smell of someone's dinner drifting from a kitchen above, light catching the water between the gables. The city does this quietly and constantly.

Day 2

The Anne Frank House: Book Months Ahead

The **Anne Frank House** on the Prinsengracht is the single most affecting hour we spent in the Netherlands. We will not say much about it because it is not the kind of thing one previews. We will say two practical things. First: tickets are sold online only, in timed slots, and they release a fixed number a set period in advance. Book the moment your dates are firm—we booked roughly two months out and slots for our preferred evening had already evaporated. Second: go in the late afternoon if you can. The light through the canal-side windows in those upper rooms, as the day fades, does something to the experience that the museum's curators clearly understood.

Day 3

Rijksmuseum, Van Gogh & a Reasonable Argument for Slowing Down

The **Rijksmuseum** is enormous and we are very glad we gave it a full half-day rather than the panicked ninety-minute sprint we had initially planned. Vermeer's *The Milkmaid* is smaller than you expect and quietly devastating in person; the room of Rembrandts that culminates in *The Night Watch* rewards standing still for ten minutes rather than two. The building itself, restored a decade or so ago, is part of the pleasure—light wells, marble staircases, a library that you can look down into.

The **Van Gogh Museum**, twenty minutes' walk away on the Museumplein, is the other essential. Seeing the late works in chronological order, in one building, with the wall labels written in Vincent's own voice through his letters to Theo, is a very different experience from encountering one or two of these paintings scattered across other collections. Book both museums online ahead of time; the on-the-day queues are mournful.

Day 4

The Jordaan, Brown Cafes & Vondelpark

The **Jordaan**, just west of the canals, used to be a working-class district and is now, inevitably, a slightly polished version of itself. It is still genuinely lovely: narrow streets, courtyards (*hofjes*) tucked behind unmarked doors, independent shops, and the city's best concentration of **brown cafes**—the small, dark, panelled neighbourhood bars that smell faintly of decades of conversation. We spent two hours in one called **Café Chris**, reading a book and drinking a small beer, and it was one of the better afternoons of the trip.

Vondelpark, on a sunny October Saturday, is the city's enormous shared garden. Everyone is there: joggers, dogs, families, a man playing a saxophone with great seriousness to nobody in particular. We walked through it on a Saturday morning on the way to the museums and again on Sunday afternoon with a coffee. Both times it felt like the most democratic space in Amsterdam.

And finally: the **Albert Cuyp Market** in De Pijp on a weekday morning is the right way to do a market here—fresh stroopwafels still warm off the iron, herring stalls, cheese towers, a flow of locals doing actual shopping. The coffeeshop scene and the Red Light District, since you'll ask: both exist, both are quieter and more ordinary than the cliché, and the Red Light District in particular has been the subject of a serious civic push to reclaim it as a neighbourhood rather than a stag-do attraction. Treat it accordingly.

Bicycle Culture: A Warning, Affectionately Given

Amsterdam has, by some accounts, more bicycles than residents. They are everywhere, ridden by everyone, at speed, with absolute right of way. The single most dangerous thing a tourist can do in this city is stand absent-mindedly in a bicycle lane—which is the bit of red asphalt between the pavement and the road, not, as your brain keeps insisting, part of the pavement. We did this exactly once on our first day and were corrected by a woman on an enormous cargo bike who rang her bell with the patient fury of a primary school teacher. Watch for the red lanes. Look both ways twice. Take a city bike out yourself on day three when you've calibrated, and you'll understand the joy of the system from the inside.

Must-Visit Places in Amsterdam

- **The Canal Ring at dusk:** Walk the Prinsengracht. No itinerary needed.
- **Anne Frank House:** Book online, months ahead. Late afternoon slot if possible.
- **Rijksmuseum:** Half a day minimum. Vermeer, Rembrandt, the building itself.
- **Van Gogh Museum:** Chronological, with his letters. Book ahead.
- **The Jordaan:** Hofjes, brown cafes, an afternoon with nowhere to be.
- **Vondelpark:** Sunny morning coffee with the whole city.
- **Albert Cuyp Market:** Weekday morning. Warm stroopwafel from the iron.
- **A canal cruise:** We resisted. We were wrong. Do it.

Rotterdam: Cube Houses, Harbour Cranes & a City That Rebuilt Itself Forward

Rotterdam is what happens when a city loses its medieval centre in a single afternoon and decides, on reflection, not to fake one back. On 14 May 1940 the Luftwaffe flattened the heart of the city in roughly fifteen minutes. What rose afterwards, slowly and then quickly, is the most architecturally adventurous city in the Netherlands and probably one of the most architecturally adventurous in Europe. Stepping off the train at **Rotterdam Centraal**—itself an enormous, faceted, silver wedge of a station—you are immediately somewhere that looks nothing at all like Amsterdam, and that is the entire point.

We came down by train from Amsterdam for two nights, half-expecting to find a sober industrial counterpoint to do a long lunch in and tick off. We left wishing we'd given it three. Rotterdam is gritty and confident and a bit cooler than you, and it has been quietly making this case for fifty years.

Day 1

The Cube Houses: Living Inside an Idea

The **Kubuswoningen**—the Cube Houses—were finished in 1984 to a design by **Piet Blom**, who decided that a residential block should look like a forest of tilted yellow cubes balanced on stalks. There are 38 of them, occupied, with one preserved as the **Show Cube** museum so you can go inside and see what it is actually like to live in a room with no vertical walls. Short answer: cramped, oddly cosy, and very clearly built by someone who was more interested in the idea than the furniture-buying. We loved it.

Standing underneath the cubes, looking up at the geometry, is also one of those satisfying urban moments where the architecture genuinely refuses to do what your eye expects. Five minutes' walk away is the **Markthal**, a 2014 horseshoe of an apartment block arched over a covered food market, the interior of the arch painted with what is reportedly Europe's largest artwork—a vast, slightly psychedelic still life of fruit, fish and flowers. It is gloriously ridiculous and the food underneath is good.

Day 1

Erasmusbrug, the Swan & the River

The **Erasmusbrug**—nicknamed *de Zwaan*, the Swan, for its single sweeping white pylon—crosses the **Nieuwe Maas** river and effectively divides the historic north bank from the redeveloped south. Walking it at sunset is the city's free signature experience. The skyline either side is a working harbour skyline, all cranes and container ships and tower blocks lit from within, with the bridge a clean white arc through the middle of it.

Rotterdam looks like a city in a very good mood about its own future. There are very few European places of which this is true. Stand on the Erasmusbrug at dusk and you will feel it immediately.

On the south bank, in the old harbour at Katendrecht, the **SS Rotterdam** sits permanently moored as a hotel and museum. We did the self-guided tour on a grey afternoon and found it genuinely worth the hour: an enormous 1950s ocean liner, the former flagship of the Holland America Line, preserved with its first-class dining rooms and engine telegraphs and the slightly melancholy grandeur of a thing built for a different age of travel.

Day 2

Witte de Withstraat & the Food-and-Drink Hour

Witte de Withstraat is the street the locals will steer you to within about ninety seconds of you asking where to eat. It runs through the cultural quarter just south of the city centre, lined with independent restaurants, bars, galleries and small late-night places, and it is the part of Rotterdam where the city's harbour-cool, art-school energy is at its highest concentration. We had a long, slow Indonesian *rijsttafel* at a place a friend's friend had recommended and finished the evening in a tiny bar two doors down whose name we never caught. This is the right way to use the street: book one thing, wander for the rest.

Around the corner, the **Museum Boijmans Van Beuningen** is partly closed for a long refurbishment but its publicly accessible **Depot**—a mirrored, bowl-shaped building behind the main museum—is open and unusual: an art storage facility that you can walk through, seeing the museum's entire collection in its working racks rather than curated on walls. It is a strange and quietly thrilling experience. Check current opening details before you go.

Day 2

Day Trip: The Kinderdijk Windmills

If you only do one day trip from Rotterdam, do **Kinderdijk**. Nineteen 18th-century windmills, lined along the polder canals where the rivers Lek and Noord meet, designated UNESCO World Heritage and looking, on a still autumn morning, like the platonic ideal of every romantic Dutch landscape painting you have ever half-noticed. There's a waterbus from the centre of Rotterdam that takes about half an hour, drops you at the site, and gets you back in time for dinner. Two of the windmills are open as small museums; the rest are still occupied. Go on a weekday if you possibly can; the weekend coach tours pile in.

What we kept coming back to, on the train home, was how completely Rotterdam refuses to be a smaller or grittier version of Amsterdam. It is its own thing. If Amsterdam is the Netherlands looking lovingly back at the 17th century, Rotterdam is the same country looking with equal seriousness at the next one. You want, ideally, to do both. You especially want to do this one.

Must-Visit Places in Rotterdam

- **Cube Houses (Kubuswoningen):** Walk underneath, then tour the Show Cube.
- **Markthal:** Lunch under Europe's largest interior artwork.
- **Erasmusbrug at sunset:** Walk it. The Swan earns its nickname.
- **SS Rotterdam:** A 1950s ocean liner you can sleep on or just tour.
- **Witte de Withstraat:** The city's food-and-bar spine.
- **Depot Boijmans Van Beuningen:** An art storage facility you can walk through.
- **Rotterdam Centraal:** Even the station is worth ten minutes of looking up.
- **Kinderdijk windmills (day trip):** Waterbus from the centre. Weekday morning.

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